

College Composition II: Notetaking Template

Why Taking Notes From Sources Matters in a Research Project

When you take notes from your sources, you're not just copying information—you're thinking, filtering, making meaning, and preparing to write. Good research papers aren't built by pasting quotes together; they're built by reading deeply, understanding others' ideas, using them purposefully, and attempting to make meaning out of what you have learned.

Here's why note-taking is essential:

1. It helps you *understand* what you're reading

Reading a source once isn't enough. Writing notes forces you to slow down and ask:

- What is the author actually saying?
- What does this information mean for *my* topic?
- Why does this information matter as I form a thesis?
- Do I agree or disagree?

If you can put an idea into your own words in your notes, you're much more likely to understand it—and explain it clearly in your paper. And remember that no more than 20% of the information you use from sources should be directly quoted anyway.

2. It prevents plagiarism

When students skip notes and go straight to writing, they often:

- Copy sentences too closely
- Forget what came from a source and what came from themselves
- “Accidentally” plagiarize

Notes help you separate:

- Direct quotes
- Paraphrased ideas
- Your own thoughts

That makes citing sources easier and safer.

3. It saves time later

Taking notes might feel slower at first, but it actually:

- Makes drafting faster because you have already done the paraphrasing, explaining, synthesizing, and thinking
- Reduces last-minute stress
- Prevents rereading the same article five times

When you sit down to write, your evidence is already organized and ready to use.

4. It helps you build an argument, not just report facts

A strong research paper is not a Wikipedia article, nor does it simply say “Source A says this. Source B says this” and so on. Notes let you:

- Compare sources
- Notice patterns or disagreements
- Decide how each source supports your claim

That’s how research turns into *argument*.

5. It gives you confidence when you write

Students who take thoughtful notes know:

- Where their information came from
- What it means
- Why they’re using it
- How it supports their ideas
- And why it matters

That confidence shows up in clearer paragraphs and stronger analysis.

Bottom line

Taking notes is how you move from collecting information to using information intelligently. It’s not busywork—it’s the academic bridge between reading and writing.

Use this template to help organize your notes. I will only take a grade on the first 20 notes (5 points each), but a research project of this length will require you to complete many more (especially if you want an A). Please limit your notes to no more than 5 per source, and remember that you must reference a minimum of 8 sources in your paper.

SAY What does the text say? Direct quote or paraphrase	MEAN What does this information mean? Make an inference. Interpret and “read between the lines.” • What does the author mean? • How can the information be interpreted? • What can be inferred? • What point is the author making?	MATTER Why does it matter? So what? What are the implications and/or possible outcomes? • Why does this information matter? • Why is this important or significant? • What are the implications or consequences of the information? • How does this connect to other ideas?
• X* states/says/writes ... • X claims/argues/insists ... • According to X, ... • X reminds us that ... • As X points out ... <i>*X is the author or source</i>	• This quote/evidence/idea + means/emphasizes/shows ... • This suggests/implies ... • In other words, X believes ... • Basically, X is saying ... • X’s point is that ...	• As a result, ... • Also/In addition, ... • For example/instance, ... • In my experience, ... • This connects/relates to ... • Knowing this will ...

Try it out:

#	How this source helps my paper:	Source Information: URL or other identifying information that will help you remember where you found the information	SAY What does the text say? Direct quote or paraphrase (not a summary) – if quoting, make sure to use quotation marks with an attribution to who said it.	MEAN What does this information mean? Make an inference. Interpret and “read between the lines.” • What does the author mean? • How can the information be interpreted? • What can be inferred? • What point is the author making?	MATTER Why does it matter? So what? What are the implications and/or possible outcomes? • Why does this information matter? • Why is this important or significant? • What are the implications or consequences of the information? • How does this connect to other ideas?
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